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California Assembly Passes Groundbreaking Bipartisan Bill Banning Harmful Ultra-Processed Food in Schools

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YONKERS, New York, June 4 -- Consumer Reports posted the following news release:

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California Assembly passes groundbreaking bipartisan bill banning harmful ultra-processed food in schools

Consumer Reports calls on Senate to support bill that directs California to identify particularly harmful ultra-processed foods to be phased out of schools

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SACRAMENTO, CA - California is one step closer to becoming the first state in the nation to ban unhealthy ultra-processed foods in public schools under bipartisan legislation approved today by the state Assembly. AB 1264, introduced by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, directs the California Office of Environmental Health Hazard Assessment (OEHHA) to define ultra-processed foods and identify particularly harmful ones to be phased out of schools by 2032. The legislation is co-sponsored by Consumer Reports and the Environmental Working Group.

Recent research has linked diets that include a lot of ultra-processed foods -- such as soft drinks and packaged snacks -- to serious health risks, including cancer, cardiovascular disease, and Type 2 diabetes. An estimated 67 percent of the calories in food eaten by children comes from ultra-processed food, according to a study published in JAMA in 2021.

"Ultra-processed foods offer little nutritional value and are deliberately engineered to make them hard to resist, which encourages unhealthy eating habits and overconsumption," said Brian Ronholm, director of food policy at Consumer Reports. "Students should be provided with healthier options instead of ultra-processed food that puts their health at risk. This bill will help protect the health of California kids and establish an important new standard for the rest of the nation by getting harmful ultra-processed food out of our schools."

The bill defines ultra-processed foods as those that contain one or more certain functional ingredients, including colors, flavors, sweeteners, emulsifiers, and thickening agents. OEHHA would be required to identify ultra-processed foods considered particularly harmful based on whether peer-reviewed evidence has linked the substance to cancer, cardiovascular disease, metabolic disease, developmental harms, reproductive harms, obesity, Type 2 diabetes; whether the substance is hyper-palatable or may contribute to food addiction; and whether the food has been modified to be high in fat, sugar and salt.

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Original text here: https://advocacy.consumerreports.org/press_release/california-assembly-passes-groundbreaking-bipartisan-bill-banning-harmful-ultra-processed-food-in-schools/

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